difference between success and failure of the invasion. It is also in line with the blueprint of Messervy's Operation Gulmarg that Kalkat had read in Bannu.

When the Maharaja appealed for help to New Delhi, he was asked to sign the Instrument of Accession, before any help was sent. Meanwhile, near New Delhi, the largest peacetime air armada of 100 planes was being organised by the Government of India to fly off hardened fighting units of the Indian Army to Srinagar, once the Instrument of Accession was signed. This happened in Jammu on 26 October 1947. Sir V. P. Menon, Principal Secretary to Sardar Patel, flew into Srinagar on 25 October and instructed the Maharaja to leave for Jammu. The Maharaja wanted a 'limited accession' of the state to India only with regard to defence, foreign affairs and communication. The Maharaja felt unprotected ever since he had been betrayed by his army and police chiefs. He wanted the protection of the Indian Army but still wanted to retain his hold on the state. Menon flew back to New Delhi with Sheikh Abdullah as sunset descended on Srinagar. That night, the Maharaja's entourage left Srinagar for Udhampur with the gold idol of the presiding deity, Lord Vishnu from the Gadadhar Temple in Srinagar. According to Sheikh Abdullah, as the caravan of cars drove into Udhampur, the Maharani sat clutching the idol with the car's hood down.[15] This picture of the Maharani made all of the Dogra onlookers at Udhampur very angry. Meanwhile, Menon landed in Jammu and obtained the Maharaja's signature to the Instrument of Accession on the morning of 26 October 1947.[16]

Accession

There was a twist in the execution and acceptance of the Instrument of Accession. Lord Mountbatten accepted the accession but added a caveat to it—this was the Indian Government's promise to ratify the accession by means of a plebiscite seeking the consent of the people of the state, regarding the accession. Why did Mountbatten enter this caveat? Why did Nehru and Patel accept it? Was this a last-ditch attempt by Ismay and his